

Life punches entrepreneurs in the face, sometimes more than once a day. There is hardly a real entrepreneur in the world who still has a straight nose. If he stands his ground and takes the punches—steadfastly enduring all that life can hit him with—he will soon be out cold on the mat.

The entrepreneur of myth is far from the real one. The real business builder knows he has to bob, weave, and duck. He has to roll with the punches, not take them in the head. And if he has a vision, he knows it is no substitute for real experience. When experience shows his vision won't work, he chucks it into the dustbin with the millions of other unworkable visions. Otherwise, he and his business will be chucked into the dustbin.

Contrary to popular myth, business builders try to avoid risks whenever they can. They soon learn that there are a lot of sucker punches in the world of business; they need to avoid them if they are to stay in business and succeed.

“Accelerated failure” is one way to control risks and find “what works” as fast as possible.

“One step at a time” is how to get where you want to go.

LEARN AT OTHERS' EXPENSE

Still another simple principle of successful business is to “learn from others' mistakes.” We have heard so many stories about successful entrepreneurs who have pioneered new industries we forget that most new innovations fail. They are like mutations in the natural world. Most disappear. Only a very few survive and produce fertile offspring. Still fewer become major successes.

The trick is not only to learn from your own experience, but to take as much from the experience of others. You don't want to be a mutation. You want to be an improvement. And you do that by studying, watching, and listening to other people who have tried to succeed in your chosen industry.

Almost every industry has its sources. Magazines, blogs, web sites, trade shows—you can learn a lot about what works just by paying attention. You may not understand the “why,” but who does? And you can check and find